When God Is the Only Friend: Belief in a Higher Power as Substitute and Supplement for Human Connection

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Abstract. This paper asks whether belief in a higher power functions as a replacement or a supplement for human connection among lonely individuals, and how that affects well-being. It synthesizes survey research, peer-reviewed psychology, and ethnography. Social isolation carries documented health costs, and religion is one of the ways people respond to it. Two mechanisms are identified. The first is communal: frequent religious attendance is associated with more close friends and family available in a crisis, and adults who remain in the faith they were raised in report closer family relationships and lower chronic loneliness than those who leave. The second is relational and does not require a congregation: in three large national datasets, higher religiosity predicts a stronger sense of purpose specifically among adults with weak social ties, and ethnographic work finds that believers who conceive of God as a personal presence derive benefits resembling close friendship. The benefit is conditional on how God is perceived, with a supportive conception associated with better mental health and a punitive one with greater distress. Religion also produces isolation where individuals fall short of community standards or leave the faith. The paper concludes that belief operates as a replacement for the most isolated and a supplement for others, and recommends that loneliness interventions treat inclusive religious communities as social infrastructure while recognising that exclusion within them can deepen the isolation they are meant to address.

Keywords. loneliness; religiosity; social connection; purpose in life; religious disaffiliation

1. INTRODUCTION

Aging erodes more than the body. Among its most consistent social effects is the loss of relationships that once supplied meaning and belonging. Haruki Murakami captures the experience in “A Walk to Kobe,” where a narrator returns to a familiar city and finds the place intact and the relationships that defined it gone.

The consequences are measurable. The U.S. Surgeon General’s 2023 advisory documents that people depend on social connection and that its absence leaves them vulnerable to deteriorating mental and physical health. One common response to that absence is religious belief (Wormley et al., 2025).

Religion occupies an unsettled place in American life, and the direction of travel is less clear than it recently appeared. In February 2024, Pew Research Center found that 80 percent of U.S. adults said religion was losing influence in American life. By February 2025 that share had fallen to 68 percent, a twelve-point drop (Rotolo et al., 2025). The perceived decline is therefore itself in flux, which matters for any argument resting on religion’s retreat. Some renewed interest among younger people appears algorithmically driven rather than the result of spiritual seeking (Akyeampong, 2025).

Research question: in what ways does belief in a higher power function as a replacement or supplement for human connection among lonely individuals, and how does this affect their overall well-being?

2. THE COMMUNAL MECHANISM

The most straightforward way religion reduces loneliness is by supplying people. Cox (2020), drawing on a nationally representative survey of American adults, finds that those who attend religious services more frequently report more close friends and family members they could rely on in a crisis. Participation appears to expand the network rather than merely reflecting the sociability of people who already have one.

The effect extends into families. Data from the American National Family Life Survey indicate that adults who remain in the religion they were raised in report closer relationships with parents and siblings and lower rates of chronic loneliness than those who have left (Survey Center on American Life, 2022). Leaving is associated with increased isolation.

One qualification is worth stating plainly, because it cuts against a simple reading. Religiously committed individuals tend to have less diverse friendship networks (Cox, 2020). The networks are denser rather than broader. For someone whose problem is having no one, density is what is needed; for someone whose problem is narrowness, it is not.

The pattern is not confined to the United States. Pew Research Center (2019), surveying across countries, finds that actively religious people report higher happiness more often than the unaffiliated or the inactively religious, though the relationship varies by country and is not uniform. The cross-national spread is useful because it weakens one obvious objection: if the effect were produced entirely by the social position of religion in American life, it should not appear in societies where religion occupies a different position.

3. THE RELATIONAL MECHANISM

The second mechanism does not require a congregation, and it is the one that answers the paper's question directly.

Chan et al. (2018), drawing on three large national U.S. datasets, find that among adults with weak social ties, higher religiosity predicts a stronger sense of purpose in life, after controlling for age, gender, education, and religious attendance. The control for attendance is what makes the finding significant: the benefit persists when communal participation is held constant, which means something other than the congregation is doing the work. Socially connected adults showed no comparable gain, because they already reported high purpose.

Sheikholeslami et al. (2012), in a smaller study of 100 retired seniors in Iran, reach a similar conclusion: stronger religious belief is associated with lower loneliness and better self-rated health. Pew Research Center (2019) finds the pattern internationally, with religious participation associated with higher reported happiness.

Luhrmann (2020) supplies the mechanism through ethnographic fieldwork in churches, neurological observation, and experiment. She finds that some believers cultivate what functions as a genuine relationship with God, addressing a presence they experience as responsive. Heartfelt prayer is associated with lower loneliness and greater capacity to handle stress.

The conditionality is the most important finding in this section. Luhrmann reports that the benefit depends on how God is perceived. A God understood as supportive and caring is associated with improved mental health and reduced loneliness; a God understood as merciless is associated with greater distress. Belief does not reliably substitute for connection. A particular kind of belief does.

4. WHERE RELIGION PRODUCES ISOLATION

The same settings that surround some people with support exclude others. Gemar (2024) finds that religion can generate loneliness when an individual is judged, or judges themselves, insufficiently devout. Guilt associated with being seen as sinful can increase distance from both the community and the conception of God that would otherwise provide comfort.

This can become self-reinforcing. Distance leads to reduced participation, reduced participation to further marginalisation, and the path ends in departure, which the disaffiliation data associate with increased loneliness and lower sense of purpose (Survey Center on American Life, 2022). Cox (2020) adds that religious identification is associated with less contact across faiths, and that people whose networks span faiths report more questioning of personal belief and higher loneliness.

Luhrmann's framework resolves the apparent contradiction between Cox and Gemar. Cox shows that religion expands social networks; Gemar shows this holds only for those who meet the community's standard. Because Chan et al. find the purpose benefit surviving a control for attendance, and because Luhrmann locates the benefit in the perceived character of God, the relational mechanism can operate for people the institution has excluded, provided the God they conceive of has not excluded them too.

5. WHAT THE EVIDENCE CANNOT SETTLE

The studies above are consistent with the paper's thesis. They are also consistent with an alternative that should be stated plainly, because no source reviewed here rules it out.

The alternative is selection. People who are lonely and who turn to religion may differ, before they turn, from lonely people who do not. If the people drawn to faith are those with a disposition toward meaning-making, or those who retain childhood ties to a congregation, then religiosity would predict lower loneliness without reducing it. The correlation would be real and the causal story backwards.

Two features of the evidence make the causal reading more credible without establishing it. Chan et al. (2018) control for religious attendance and still find the purpose benefit concentrated among the socially disconnected, which means the result is not explained by participation differences alone. Luhrmann (2020) identifies a specific mechanism, the perceived character of God, that

predicts the direction of the effect; a selection story has to explain why that particular variable should matter, and no obvious explanation is available.

Neither point is decisive. The design that would settle the question follows people through a period of social loss and measures whether religiosity changes before or after loneliness does. That study does not appear in the literature reviewed here.

6. DISCUSSION

Two conclusions follow. Belief in a higher power operates as a replacement for human connection among the most isolated, and as a supplement for those with weakened but existing networks. Both functions are associated with improved well-being: less loneliness, more purpose, and some buffering of the health consequences the Surgeon General documents.

The limits deserve equal weight. The benefits are conditional on the type of religious environment and on the perception of God, and the evidence is correlational throughout. People who are already lonely may be drawn to religion, rather than religion reducing their loneliness, and none of the studies reviewed here can separate the two directions.

7. RECOMMENDATIONS

Loneliness interventions should treat inclusive religious communities as existing social infrastructure rather than building parallel structures, since congregations already perform the function at scale.

Practitioners should attend to how an individual conceives of God rather than to religiosity as a single measure. On Luhrmann's evidence, the two conceptions point in opposite directions, and a measure that does not distinguish them will average out a real effect.

Programs serving people who have left a faith should recognise disaffiliation as a specific risk factor, because the disaffiliation data associate leaving with both increased loneliness and reduced sense of purpose.

8. LIMITATIONS

No original data. This paper synthesizes published research and collects none of its own.

Correlation, not causation. Every association reported here is observational. The direction between loneliness and religiosity cannot be established from this evidence.

Sample limitations. The Sheikholeslami study covers 100 retired seniors in one country. Survey work by Cox and the Survey Center on American Life is U.S.-based and may not generalise across religious traditions.

Self-reported measures. Loneliness, purpose, and perception of God are measured by self-report, which is subject to social desirability effects, particularly on religious questions.

Moving baseline. Public perception of religion's influence shifted by twelve points between the 2024 and 2025 Pew surveys. Claims resting on a long-term decline in religious influence should be dated carefully.

9. CONCLUSION

For people with few remaining social ties, belief in a higher power appears to perform the work that human relationships otherwise perform: comfort, purpose, belonging, and some protection against the health effects of isolation. The effect is strongest precisely where human connection is weakest, which is what distinguishes it from a general benefit of religiosity.

It is also conditional, in a way that limits what can be recommended. A congregation that excludes, or a God conceived of as punitive, deepens the isolation it is meant to relieve. A stronger follow-up study would follow individuals longitudinally through periods of social loss, measuring perception of God alongside loneliness, which would address the direction-of-causation problem this paper cannot.

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CONTRIBUTIONS

Salar Khan, sole author, developed the research question, selected and reviewed the sources, distinguished the communal and relational mechanisms and their conditions, and wrote the manuscript.